Marini's writings on sub-imperialism will be discussed through the prism of each of the MDT levels of abstraction to which they belong. As we will put it, they are the distinct instances or components of the totality.[4] The phenomenon is not equal to the sum of its parts. As a totality, sub-imperialism only exists in the dialectic that arises out of the articulation of the historical determinations that constitute its essence. Lack of theoretical clarity for understanding this totality and its essence causes confusion about Marini's category not only among rival theoreticians who praise the Brazilian bourgeoisie but also other critics, including contemporary Marxist ones.

What is sub-imperialism? As we hope to show, sub-imperialism has to be understood as a hierarchical level of the world system and at the same time as a stage of dependent capitalism (its highest stage) out of which some socio-economic formations are transformed into new links in the imperialist chain without ever leaving the condition of economic dependency. Besides transferring value to imperialist centres, they also move into appropriating the surplus value of weaker nations for themselves. The socio-economic formations that ascend to the sub-imperialist condition succeed in displacing the very conditions of dependent capitalism in a way that ensures expanded reproduction and mitigates the effects of dependency through forms that are specific to the pattern of capital reproduction and a policy of antagonistic cooperation with dominant imperialism in different situations; they claim relative autonomy for the sub-imperialist state without, however, questioning the framework of dependency.

A hierarchical level of the world system

The worldwide appearance of imperialism and sub-imperialism constitutes global capitalism's coming-of-age with passage to the phase of monopoly and finance capital – a process that occurs first in the centre and then in the periphery. For this reason its examination must begin at the level of abstraction of the capitalist system framed by the entrance of capitalism into a new stage as a world system. If the historical advent of imperialism dates back to the turn of the 19th century, sub-imperialism dates from the new integrationist tendency of world capitalism that arises out of post-World War II capital movements.

> The expansion and acceleration not only of the circulation of productive capital but also of money have been shaping a new capitalist world economy that rests upon a structure of international division of labour distinct from that which ruled before the world crisis … The era of the simple centre-periphery model characterised by the exchange of manufactures